

Evaluating radicalization through autism diagnosis criteria and media addiction

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ABSTRACT

Current research on autism and radicalization tends to approach autism in one of two limiting ways: as a homogenous group without considering variation within diagnostic criteria, or through narrow, journalistic case studies that lack broader applicability. This study will identify specific categories of autism diagnostic criteria that might influence susceptibility to radicalization, rather than viewing autistic populations as uniform. The role of the internet in this process of radicalization is irrefutable, so media use behaviors will be accounted for as a moderating variable. Using the *Ritvo Autism Asperger Diagnostic Scale Revised* to evaluate autism symptomatology in conjunction with the *Problematic Media Use Measure* to evaluate digital media addiction, the *Extremism Scale* to evaluate radicalization, and the *Pro-violence and Illegal Acts in Relation to Extremism Scale* to evaluate violent extremist ideology reveals that extremism is most correlated with circumscribed interests and violent extremism is most correlated with sensory/motor deficiencies. Problematic media use was not a significant moderating factor. This information should be used to construct a foundation for informed radicalization prevention support systems and programs.

Keywords: Autism, ASD, Neurodivergence, Political Extremism, Radicalization, Terrorism

I. INTRODUCTION

Radicalism is an increasingly prevalent issue in the internet age, where targeted media can disrupt social relationships to persuade vulnerable individuals towards extremist acts of terrorism (Koehler, 2014). Thus, it is particularly important that precautions are taken to aid likely victims of extremist ideology, who are suspected to be predominantly autistic individuals (Gojer et al., 2024). The findings below should be used to formulate more individualized prevention measures for autistic individuals at risk of radicalization and, consequently, reduce acts of violent extremism. Autism spectrum disorder is a neurological and developmental disorder comprised of varying behavioral and developmental traits on a continuum (Meade-Kelly, 2016). Speculation of if autism and radicalism are connected is largely approached by comparing the amount of autistic extremists to allistic (non-autistic) extremists. This does not demonstrate why an autistic person may be vulnerable to radicalization and, therefore, cannot inform radicalization prevention measures. Instead, categorizing autism diagnostic criteria into four distinct categories (social relatedness, language, circumscribed interests, and sensory motor) and quantifying the severity of these in comparison to severity of extremist values will illustrate specific predictors of radicalism. In turn, this will better represent the broad autism spectrum by not seeing autistics as part of one homogenous group (Natalie Engelbrecht, Eva Silvertant, 2022). This can be done by utilizing the *Ritvo Autism Asperger Diagnostic Scale Revised* (RAADS-R) to quantify autism, the *Extremism Scale* (ES) to quantify extremist values, and the *Pro-Violence and Illegal Acts in Relation to Extremism Scale* (PIARES) to quantify violent extremism (Ozer, Bertelsen, 2018).

Radicalism is an increasingly prevalent issue in the internet age, where targeted media can disrupt social relationships to persuade vulnerable individuals towards extremist acts of terrorism (Koehler, 2014). It is essential to implement radicalization prevention methods due to their severe effects on interpersonal relationships and broader societal stability. A radicalized individual might disengage from relationships due to their intensive focus on a specific idea or goal (Zych and Nasaescu, 2021). Consequently, relationships suffer when the resources provided by a family are lost upon the individual, along with other aspects of life. Globally, radicalism has escalated to become one of the most prominent concerns. Reversing nearly a decade of improvements, the 12th annual Global Terrorism Index recorded an increase from 58 to 66 in the number of countries recording a terrorist attack (Institute for Economics & Peace, 2025). The intensification of violence in the four deadliest terrorist groups

in 2024 led to an 11% rise in fatalities. Millions of people worldwide have fallen victim to acts of violent extremism, having been killed, disabled, displaced, widowed, or orphaned (Qadeem, 2020).

A growing body of public discourse suggests that the most vulnerable group to radicalization is overwhelmingly autistic, but a direct causal link between autism and radicalization has yet to be empirically established (Borrell, 2020; Soares et al., 2022). However, there is a trend among scholars to try to correlate two topics by viewing autistic people as a homogeneous group, which does not account for varying autistic experiences (Allely & Faccini, 2017; King, 2020). Preexisting studies that analyze the association between radicalization and autism face several limitations in methodology, necessitating empirical expansion and larger sample sizes to draw more informed conclusions about the study. These preexisting studies are typically case studies, where the relationship between autism and radicalization is analyzed through the factors in experiences of specific individuals. Borrell (2020) relies on interviews of individuals already engaged with radical online communities, focusing on young autistic men's experience with social rejection. Soares and colleagues (2022) expanded on autistic individuals' struggles, using statistical information to reinforce that societal factors like disenfranchisement, stigma, and bullying can develop into vulnerability for joining radicalized groups as a coping mechanism. This gap in nuance can be filled by examining how validated measures for autism, radicalization, and media addiction explain how autism impacts radicalization, thereby helping to establish a framework for deradicalization of autistic individuals.

Conjecture on autism and radicalization often suggests that certain features of autism diagnostic criteria may lead to extremism, as numerous studies identify features and individual examples of this correlation (Gojer et al., 2024; Wijekoon et al., 2024). The most likely characteristic target of extremist beliefs is social isolation. Isolation is believed to be more prominent in autistic populations than in allistic populations because of the social deficits characteristic of autism, including communication, behavior, learning, and interpersonal relationship deficits (Woodbury-Smith, 2022). The relationship between these traits and radicalization through online communities is still demonstrated mainly through qualitative observations and analyses of pre-existing medical data; more empirical evidence is needed to understand an overarching connection and quantify how specific deficits interact with radicalization (Soares et al., 2022; Little et al., 2021). Moreover, an increasing number of individuals are utilizing online platforms as a tool to connect with others and create communities, which can be a positive experience for autistic people who struggle with in-person relationships (Welch et al., 2022). However, there is also an increased exposure risk to extremist propaganda with increased online activity (Allely et al., 2024). Although deradicalization campaigns are also available online, they are often deemed to be impersonal, ineffective, and overall not capable of reversing the effects of extremist propaganda (Mughal et al., 2023). Future sustained support systems should be personalized to address the unmet needs of a vulnerable, socially isolated individual.

Early prevention methods that aim to provide guidance and divert individuals from extremist beliefs are considered more effective than deradicalization methods, which seek to dissuade an individual who has adopted a defensive stance. Furthermore, individuals who have already adopted extremist ideas may experience reinforcement of their beliefs by consciously seeking consonant perspectives within echo chambers, thereby further polarizing their views (Kelly, 2021). Cognitive dissonance theory suggests an inclination to reduce dissonance and thus reject alternatives, such as deradicalization attempts (Harmon-Jones & Mills, 2019). In addition, the sunk-cost effect describes the reluctance of individuals to opt out of a course of action due to prior investment made (Dijkstra, 2019). This suggests that by the time an individual solidifies and invests in extremist values, it is challenging to process or accept non-conforming information.

While some academics argue that autism increases vulnerability to radicalization, others believe autism is overrepresented in extremist groups (Moseley, 2025). However, neither group seems to have statistically identified autistic traits that premeditate radicalization, a gap this study aims to fill. The academics that assert autism is overrepresented in extremist groups denounce a direct correlation between radicalization and autism, instead linking radicalization to the aforementioned risk factors that can be derived from autism (Goodwin, 2025). Although trauma, isolation, and disenfranchisement remain pervasive risks, autism should not be generalized as

synonymous with violence, and a broader-scoped study is needed to better understand the disorder's correlation to radicalization (Wijekoon et al., 2024).

There are other limitations in past literature, like a lack of general statistical correlation and a lack of consolidated traits that necessitate a broader-scoped study. A study by Rousseau and colleagues (2023) uses Autism Diagnostic Observation Schedule and Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, Fifth Edition models to measure autism spectrum disorder traits, finding that extremism risk traits like social adversity are more prevalent in autistic individuals than in allistic individuals. However, it does not establish a direct associative link between autism and radicalization so as to avoid overgeneralization or stigmatization of autistic individuals, which has been a primary limitation for qualitative analyses (Rousseau et al., 2023). The overgeneralization of autistic individuals has led to erroneous risk identification. For example, Allely and colleagues (2024) found that a disproportionate amount of autistic individuals were referred to Prevent (the UK government's anti-radicalization program) (Allely et al., 2023). However, these individuals were referred for preoccupations with terrorism that involved no operational behavior or threat (Allely et al., 2024). Likewise, sensationalized media reports often connect terrorist attacks to neurodivergence, even when there is no causal link (Goodwin, 2025). More general studies would likely allow for a more nuanced consideration of all individuals on a spectrum of autism rather than a definitively diagnosed condition. They can also more accurately pinpoint traits of vulnerability in autistic individuals by statistical means.

Current literature pertaining to autism and radicalization provides qualitative studies and analyses that evaluate autism's role in radicalization. This research commonly presents finding solace in extremist online communities as a coping mechanism for struggles often (but not always or only) faced by autistic people. They also closely examine the personal and societal consequences of radicalization, focusing on the difficulty of deradicalization.

To study vulnerability for radicalization through autistic traits while avoiding generalizations, validated scales should be used to measure extremism's dependency on specific characteristics of autism and how media use moderates this connection. The ES and PIARES scores will be evaluated as dependent variables, contingent on participants' RAADS-R scores and subscores (the independent variables). The strength of the relationship between these two variables is speculated to be influenced by the Problematic Media Use Measure (PMUM), the moderating variable. There are two hypotheses that predict the relationship between these variables. H_1 predicts that social-related symptoms of autism will positively correlate with radicalization, and H_2 suggests that compulsive media addiction will increase radicalization. This study aims to provide a foundation for the establishment of informed radicalization prevention support systems and programs.

II. METHODOLOGY

Sample

77 participants ($M_{age} = 39.21$, $SD_{age} = 13.9$) were recruited personally by researchers and via Prolific, a website where participants are paid for their completion of online surveys. Of the 77 total responses, 10 responses were invalid due to a lack of consent or a nonfulfillment of the survey criteria, which required participants to have American nationality and be of 18 years or older, and 1 extreme outlier was omitted. Our final sample consisted of 66 participants ($M_{age} = 39.92$, $SD_{age} = 13.8$). 58 were recruited through Prolific, a website where participants are paid for their completion of online surveys, and the remainder were recruited personally by researchers. 56% were assigned female at birth and 44% of participants were assigned male at birth. 67% were White/Caucasian, 15% were Black/African American, 9% of participants were Asian/Pacific Islander, 6% were Hispanic/Latino, 2% were Native American/Alaskan Native, and 2% were Biracial/Multiracial.

Procedure

Following informed consent, participants completed demographic questions on ethnicity/race, biological sex, age, Prolific ID (if they were completing the survey via Prolific), and nationality (confirming American nationality). Participants were then presented with instructions to complete the RAADS-R (Engelbrecht & Silvertant, 2025) assessment through a hyperlink and were prompted to report their overall score and four subscores. Next, participants were brought back to the survey page and completed the ES (Ozer & Bertelsen,

2018), PIARES (Ozer & Bertelsen, 2018), and the PMUM (Domoff et al., 2019). Upon completion of the survey, participants were thanked for their time and redirected back to Prolific to receive payment for their participation.

Measures

Ritvo Autism Asperger Diagnostic Scale-Revised (RAADS-R)

The RAADS-R (Engelbrecht & Silvertant, 2025) is an 80-item self-report questionnaire based on the International Classification of Diseases, Tenth Revision and Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, 5th Edition (American Psychiatric Association, 2022). This questionnaire includes prompts such as “I like to copy the way certain people speak and act. It helps me appear more normal.” The RAADS-R relies on a four-point scale consisting of “true now and when I was young”, “true only now”, “true only when I was younger than 16”, and “never true” to evaluate lifelong autism traits. 64 of these questions ask about specific symptoms of ASD and 16 questions ask about non symptomatic (normative) behaviors. The symptomatic answers are scored by severity from 0 to 3, with “never true” scoring at the bottom at 0 and “true now and when I was young” scoring at the top at 3. The normative answers are interpreted inversely, with “never true” scoring at the top at 3. These individual scores are then summed to form an overall RAADS-R score and subcategory scores.

The definite meaning of each of the four subcategories of the RAADS-R test consists of several autism related behaviors; these associated behaviors must be contextualized for effective interpretation. The circumscribed interests subcategory describes an individual's particular focus on specific details instead of the bigger picture, affinity towards uncommon interests, and heavy emotional focus for continuity with preexisting expectations. The sensory motor subcategory encompasses difficulty with the receiving and delivery of touch and sound. It includes difficulty with controlling speaking volume, speaking tone, and motor skills, as well as occasional overwhelming overstimulation. The social relatedness subcategory consists of the interpersonal interaction skillset, whether that be understanding the feelings of others or social cues, a tendency to be overly blunt in conversation, or having challenges maintaining relationships. Similar to the social relatedness subcategory, the language subcategory also includes accidental bluntness. Individuals who have a higher numerical score in language may also have difficulty making small talk and have a tendency to use phrases from the media.

Extremism Scale (ES) and Pro-violence and Illegal Acts in Relation to Extremism Scale (PIARES)

Filling a prior lack of generalized and validated measures of extremism, Ozer and Bertelsen (2018) developed the ES and the PIARES as questionnaires to evaluate extremism in terms of attitude toward sociocultural change and intolerance toward others through group dynamics. The ES measures extremism and the PIARES measures violent extremism. The ES includes statements such as “In the end, there must be a confrontation – one can't forever live peacefully, side by side with people who live a completely different life than they are obligated to live” that participants rate their agreement with on a seven-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 (“strongly and completely disagree”) to 7 (“strongly and completely agree”). The sum of the participants' ratings for each question was taken for an overall extremism score. The violent extremism scale consists of two sets of questions, the first expressing beliefs beginning with “Using physical violence is the only thing that works when it is a matter of...” and finishing with clauses such as “creating proper conditions with whom one feels a solidarity.” The second set of questions begins with “Breaking the law is the only thing that really works when it is a matter of...” with the same choices to finish the statement as from the first half. Participants rated their agreement with each completed statement on a seven-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 (“strongly and completely disagree”) to 7 (“strongly and completely agree”). The sum of the participants' ratings for each question was taken for an overall violent extremism score.

Problematic Media Use Measure (PMUM)

The PMUM (Domoff et al., 2019) assesses addictive online behaviors with 11 items, including “My screen media use hurts my relationships” and “The amount of time that I want to use screen media keeps increasing”. Items are rated on a five-point scale of never, rarely, very often, and always to ask questions about addictive behaviors online. The ratings for each question were summed for an overall problematic media use score; higher overall scores represent greater severity of media addiction as opposed to a lower overall score.

Typically, questions in the PMUM are provided to a child's parental figure, who then completes the survey based on their understanding of their own child. However, since all participants recruited from Prolific were over the age of 18, we used a modified version from the PMUM that asked participants to self-report.

Statistical analysis

The data collected from this survey was analyzed using correlational tests and multiple linear regression models in R (R Core Team, 2021). Correlations were conducted between each of the five RAADS-R metrics (overall RAADS-R score, social relatedness score, language score, sensory-motor score, and circumscribed interests score) with extremism scores and with violent extremism scores, respectively. We conducted follow-up multiple linear regression analyses to examine the potential moderating role of internet addiction severity. Participants were categorized into high- or low-internet addiction severity groups following a median split of the PMUM scores. This binarized variable was used as the interactive term in the multiple linear regression models.

III. RESULTS / ANALYSIS (12pt)

To test our hypothesis that social relatedness will have the highest positive correlation with radicalization, we conducted a Pearson correlation analysis to test the relationship between the four RAADS-R subscores and overall RAADS-R score to the extremism and violent extremism measures. To systematically compare participants with higher vs. lower compulsive media use and observe its moderating effects, a median split was created to create a high problematic media use group and a low problematic media use group. The correlation coefficient (r) was used in this study as a statistical measure of the strength and direction of a relationship.

We first examined the association between extremism scores with the overall RAADS-R score ($M = 82.2$, $SD = 48.9$), and the following RAADS-R subscales: Circumscribed Interests ($M = 17.2$, $SD = 11.5$), Language ($M = 11.4$, $SD = 15.1$), Sensory Motor ($M = 20.7$, $SD = 15.5$), and Social Relatedness ($M = 35.6$, $SD = 22.7$). Correlational analyses revealed significant, positive associations between extremism scores and all RAADS-R scores, with the strongest association observed between extremism and Circumscribed Interests ($r = 0.65$, $p < 0.001$) (Figure 1). To further explore potential associations of specific autism dimensions with violent extremism, we conducted correlational analyses between the five RAADS-R scores with violent extremism scores. We found significant, positive associations between violent extremism scores with all RAADS-R scores except Language ($p = 0.052$). Sensory Motor scores were found to have the strongest correlation with violent extremism scores ($r = 0.59$, $p < 0.001$) (Figure 2; see Table 1 for all correlation results).

To test the potential moderating role of problematic media use between autism and radicalization, we separated PMUM scores into two groups using a median split, high and low, and ran a linear regression for each group. We found that problematic media use did not moderate how autism and extremism are related, since a higher or lower PMUM score did not increase or decrease the strength of the relationship, and there was no statistical significance ($t = 0.158$, $p = 0.87$). Similarly, we ran a linear regression with high and low PMUM scores to see if it moderated the relationship between autism and violent extremism. Since there was no statistical significance, problematic media use was not a moderator for autism and violent extremism either ($t = 0.049$, $p = 0.96$).

Media use from the PMUM scores ($M = 24.7$, $SD = 10.6$) did not have a moderating effect, but it did have significant individual relationships with overall autism scores, violent extremism scores ($M = 35.8$, $SD = 22.1$), and extremism scores ($M = 47.9$, $SD = 20.5$). To examine the potential association between autism traits with problematic media use, we conducted a correlation on overall RAADS-R scores with PMUM scores, which revealed that a greater presence of multi-dimensional autism traits was significantly associated with more severe problematic media use ($r = 0.56$, $p < 0.001$). We then inspected the relation between problematic media use and violent extremism, and using the PMUM scores and PIARES scores, we ran a correlation test (Figure 3). Greater severity of problematic media use was moderately related to a higher violent extremist perspective ($r = 0.49$, $p < 0.001$). Finally, we ran a correlation on the ES scores and PMUM scores to examine the possible relationship between extremism with problematic media use (Figure 4). Problematic media use had the strongest positive correlation with extremism as opposed to autism and violent extremism, suggesting that those with more severe problematic media use displayed a greater amount of extremist beliefs ($r = 0.61$, $p < 0.001$).

Table 1

r-coefficients and p-values from the relationship between Extremism Scale and RAADS-R.

RAADS-R Categories	r-coefficient	p-value
Extremism Scale (ES)		
Overall Score	0.53	< 0.001***
Circumscribed Interests	0.65	< 0.001***
Language	0.30	0.015
Sensory Motor	0.56	< 0.001***
Social Relatedness	0.37	0.0023**
Pro-violence and Illegal Acts in Relation to Extremism Scale (PIARES)		
Overall Score	0.47	< 0.001***
Circumscribed Interests	0.54	< 0.001***
Language	0.24	0.052
Sensory Motor	0.59	< 0.001***
Social Relatedness	0.30	0.015

Note. “*” is < 0.05, “**” < 0.01, “***” < 0.001

Table 2

R-coefficients, p-values, and confidence intervals for the individual relationships between overall RAADS-R, ES, PIARES, and PMUM

Relationships	r-coefficient	p-value	Confidence Interval
PMUM & ES	0.61	< 0.001***	0.95
PMUM & RAADS-R	0.56	< 0.001***	0.95
PMUM & PIARES	0.49	< 0.001***	0.95

Note. “*” is < 0.05, “**” < 0.01, “***” < 0.001

Table 3

T-statistics and p-values for combined interactions between ES/PIARES, RAADS-R, and PMUM

Relationships	t-statistic	p-value
ES & RAADS-R & PMUM	0.158	0.87
PIARES & RAADS-R & PMUM	0.049	0.96

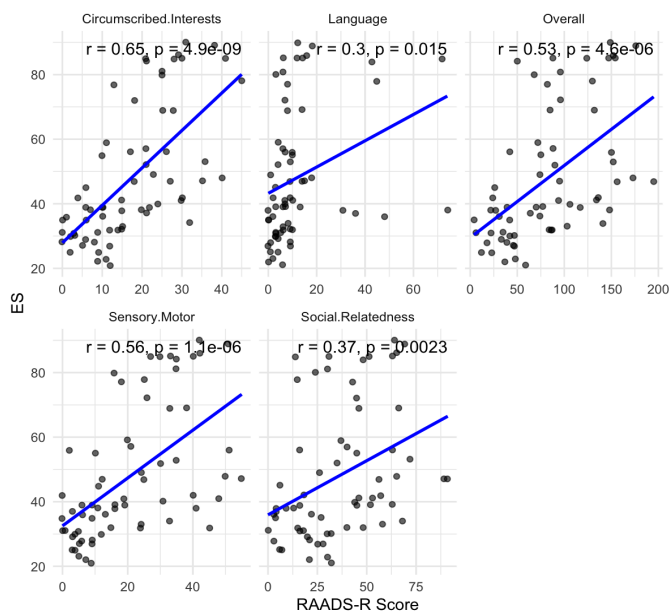


Fig 1. ES and (Overall, Social, Language, Sensory Motor, and Circumscribed Interest) with line of best fit and r value and p value

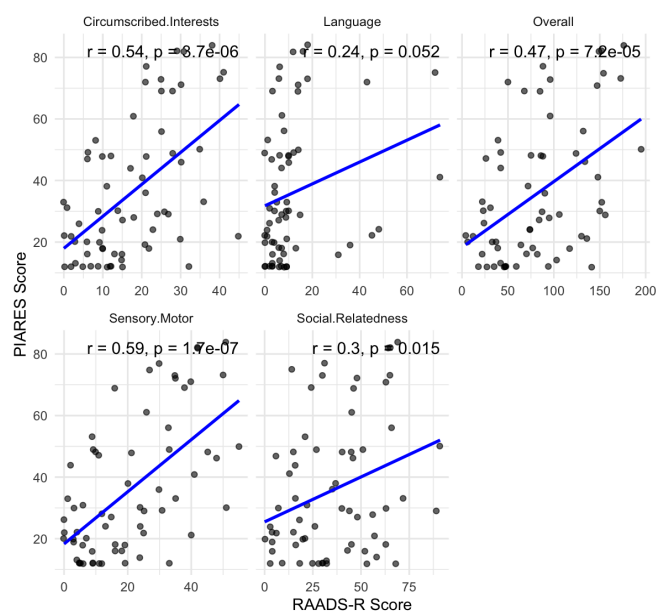


Fig 2. PIARES and (Overall, Social, Language, Sensory Motor, and Circumscribed Interest) with line of best fit and r value and p value

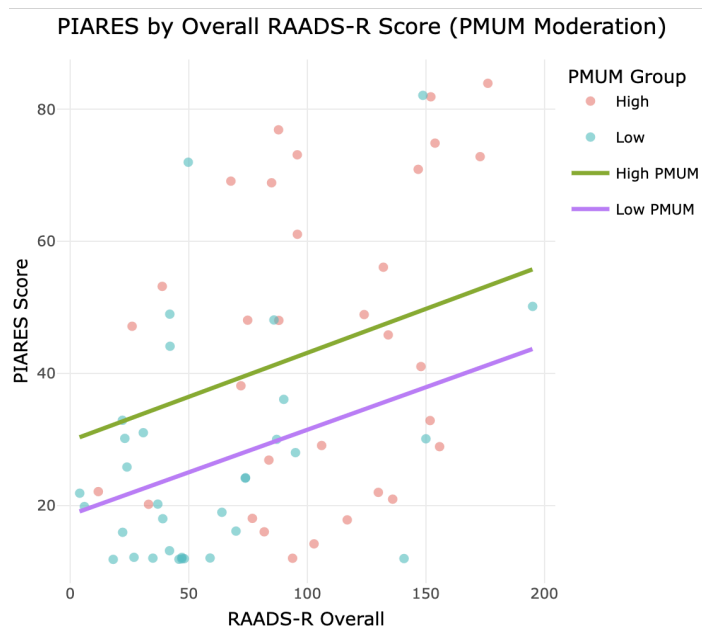


Fig 3. Plots on the graph relating PIARES and Overall RAADS-R scores were categorized into the high or low group of PMUM score

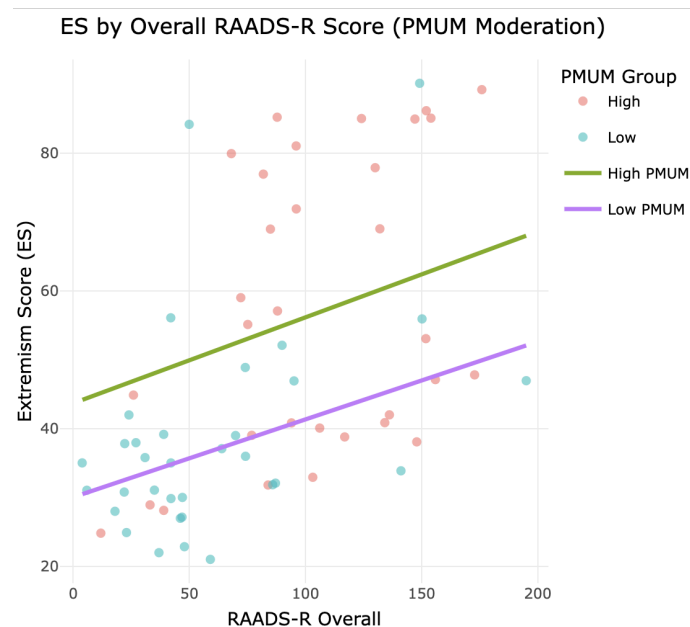


Fig 4. Plots on the graph relating ES and Overall RAADS-R scores were categorized into the high or low group of PMUM score

IV. DISCUSSION / CONCLUSION

The purpose of this study was to examine how specific categories of autism diagnostic criteria influence susceptibility to radicalization statistically and how media addiction moderates these variables. Different subcategories of autism on the RAADS-R scale had varying significant correlational relationships with extremism scores and violent extremism scores. Generally though, the results displayed statistically significant relationships between ASD and radicalization, with the only exception being the language subcategory.

Significant positive correlations were found between the multicategorical autism score with both extremism scores and violent extremism scores. These results supported preexisting case studies that identify ASD as a pertinent factor in the radicalization process (Borrell, 2020; Soares et al., 2022). The results from the separate subcategories of the RAADS-R did not support H_1 , which predicted that there would be the greatest correlation between social relatedness with both the ES and PIARES. Instead, the circumscribed interests score had the strongest correlation with the former, and the sensory motor score with the latter. H_1 was formulated through investigating past literature; yet, the suspected role of social relatedness in radicalization is reflected only partly in these findings, having the third strongest correlation with the PIARES and ES. Past research points toward social isolation as a determining trait in causing radicalization; social isolation is also closely related, but not synonymous with the behaviors of social relatedness in RAADS-R (Rousseau et al., 2023; Wijekoon et al., 2024). Although it is present, the role of social isolation may be overdeveloped in literature, as this study's findings suggested that behaviors associated with sensory motor and circumscribed interests were more closely correlated and statistically impactful. These two subcategories may provide separate, stronger explanations for radicalization or even lead to social isolation. The results also did not support H_2 , as there was a lack of significance in problematic media use scores as a moderating variable in this study. Problematic media use was not a moderating variable for either RAADS-R and ES or RAADS-R and PIARES, it was instead significantly correlated with each score separately.

The ES was most correlated to circumscribed interests. Circumscribed interests are often to the exclusion of other activities and social interactions; if people only consume media from one source or do not interact with outside influences, they may be more likely to develop extreme values. In contrast, violent extremism was most significantly correlated with sensory and motor deficits. Sensory and motor deficits are often difficult to mask, causing difficulties integrating into neurotypical society and leading people to deviant communities. Violent communities are inherently nonconformist, so people drawn to unconventionality may be more likely to develop violent extremist values.

In the context of both the ES and the PIARES, language was the least relevant factor (little correlation to ES and insignificant correlation to PIARES). Language deficits are not as prevalent as other traits outlined in the RAADS-R, as depicted by language's low threshold for autism consideration (Engelbrecht & Silvertant, 2025). Language deficits also tend to be relatively socially acceptable, as neurotypical and neurodivergent groups both report being bored by small talk, struggling with sarcasm, and quoting media in conversation. Therefore, people who struggle with language are not particularly predisposed to radicalization, as they will not be driven to extremist communities. Although social relatedness was expected to be the factor most correlated with ES/PIARES, it was third on both scales. Extremist groups systematically prey on isolated individuals with little social connections (Wood, 2020). However, social awkwardness does not equate to social isolation, reducing the effect of social relatedness on radicalization.

This study was conducted in a time of high political tension, with 76% of 1,381 Americans feeling that democracy is under threat, 73% saying political violence is a major problem, and very low overall faith in current political powers (Montanaro, 2025). If a similar study were to be conducted during a less stressful political environment, the results might have observable changes in how participants responded to the extremism ideologies presented by the ES and PIARES.

An unexpected finding of this study suggests that problematic media use was not a moderating factor, but simultaneously reveals significant individual relationships with violent extremism, extremism, or autism. It is crucial to further investigate the role of media as a moderating variable; it could be speculated from our small sample size that the moderation effects were subtle and a larger sample size is needed to better identify media's moderating effects. Significant independent relationships of media with violent extremism, extremism, or autism support a strong moderate correlation. Problematic media use may increase exposure to radicalized perspectives or even violent extremist groups, which may explain the correlation between PMUM scores with PIARES and ES scores. The autistic population may find more solace or like-minded individuals in online spaces, which potentially elaborates on the positive correlation between the RAADS-R scores with the PMUM. Drawing on these ideas, future research can be conducted to investigate exactly how these variables are related, perhaps in a more causal manner.

There are a number of considerable strengths in the current study that should be replicated in future research. The participants in this study exhibited a wide range of ages, races, and sexes, thus ensuring that the observed statistical trend is applicable across a variety of demographics in the United States. Using the platform Prolific also gave an adequate monetary incentive to participants and allowed for the removal of low-effort responses, allowing for most responses to be accurate to the genuine experiences and opinions of participants.

Some limitations of the current study need to be addressed in order for effective future research on this topic. With the data being collected overnight, a major concern was the cognitive functioning of participants when they completed the survey. Even accounting for time differences, the survey responses were predominantly completed late at night or very early in the morning across the United States. Moreover, this study only counted for 66 valid participants, and a larger sample size is suggested for higher accuracy in identifying the correlation between each RAADS-R subcategory and radicalization. In this study design, problematic media use was tested as a moderator, but causal questions like why a lower PMUM score led to higher extremism scores or violent extremism scores were not answered, pointing to a potential area for expansion. This study's survey was also only available to those with American nationality, to keep a control of every participant having a representative democracy government. Future research can explore the difference in susceptibility of ASD individuals under different forms of government across the world.

Radicalization is a process, and this study's cross sectional data only provides a snapshot of this dynamic transformation. Therefore, future studies can aim to track individuals over time and examine trajectories of radicalization tendencies, emphasizing whether the ASD traits with the highest correlation with radicalization found in this study (circumscribed interests and sensory motor), predict future risk. Factors such as trauma history, political engagement, educational level, and gender were not considered, limiting causal conclusions. For a more detailed perspective of the relationship between the ASD traits of circumscribed interests and sensory motor with the susceptibility to radicalization, these factors should be accounted for and elaborated on.

In light of increasingly prominent media-informed radicalization that engenders extremist acts of terrorism and disrupts social relationships, it is imperative that precautions are taken to aid likely victims of extremist ideology. The autistic population often manifests cognitive patterns that influence vulnerability for radicalization, which this study alluded to in those with circumscribed interests or sensory motor deficits. To develop more accurate prevention measures that better contextualize the nature of online radicalization moving forward from this study's findings, the aforementioned gaps in causality and methods should be rectified.

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AUTHOR CONTRIBUTION STATEMENT

All authors collaborated to conceive the experiment/methodology. All authors developed the survey and sourced participants for data E.W. analyzed. All authors wrote/reviewed the manuscript. Grammar AI was used to check the punctuation of this paper.